

North Carolina - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-bubble / lower-middle Power 4 quality with a plausible offensive rebound under QB Billy Edwards Jr. and Bobby Petrino.
Preseason consensus	SP+ No.56 (+3.5) · AP unranked, zero votes · ACC preseason poll 15th (831 points)
Returning production	44% - No.101 overall · Off. 47% - No.95 · Def. 42% - No.103
Primer power rating	+3.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.3 wins · most likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ Modestly better - A named veteran QB and OC Bobby Petrino raise the floor, but low continuity and rebuilt OL/defense cap the rebound.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Bobby Petrino builds a power-run, protection-first offense around announced QB Billy Edwards Jr., with situational tempo and a greater emphasis on chunk plays.

Bottom line: North Carolina has a credible bowl path because QB and play-calling are clearer, but transfer dependence plus defensive/special-teams uncertainty keeps the projection near the ACC middle class.

Beats expectations if: QB Billy Edwards Jr. is efficient early, the rebuilt OL supports OC Bobby Petrino's run/protection plan, and EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude plus the new front creates pressure.

Disappoints if: OL problems preserve 2025-level inefficiency, the new defense misses LB/DB veterans, and DC Steve Belichick or K Rece Verhoff availability adds further instability.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Billy Edwards Jr. is the announced starter for the Aug. 29 TCU opener; UNC's QB1 is settled.
- 2 Coaching:** Bobby Petrino is the new OC and offensive play-caller, with a power-run/protection-first plan, situational tempo and an emphasis on creating chunk plays.
- 3 2025 baseline:** UNC returns only 44% overall production (No.101) and 42% on defense (No.103); EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude is the clearest proven defensive anchor after a 10.5-sack 2025.
- 4 Defense: ?** Steve Belichick remained on medical leave in the latest status, and the exact 2026 defensive game-day caller was not established.
- 5 ? Key uncertainty:** K Rece Verhoff is unavailable after the Aug. 21 appellate stay; K Harrison Burrell and K Dominic Green are the contingencies.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (2-6 ACC)	● Poor
Scoring	19.2 PPG	● Poor
Total offense	288.8 YPG	● Very poor
Rush offense	105.2 YPG · 3.7 YPC	● Very poor
Pass efficiency	6.20 YPA · 13 TD / 6 INT	● Below average
Third downs	36.9%	● Below average
Scoring defense	24.5 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	336.9 YPG allowed	● Good / above average
Rush defense	125.7 YPG · 3.5 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	211.2 YPG · 6.58 YPA · 15 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

North Carolina's offense was one of the ACC's weakest conventional units across scoring, yardage and rushing. The defense was materially better, especially against the run, but not strong enough to compensate.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-5.03 · No. 111	● Poor
Off. EPA/play	-0.101 · No. 109	● Poor
Off. success rate	38.9% · No. 110	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	10.0% · No. 116	● Poor
Havoc allowed	17.0% · No. 106	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.06 · No. 65	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.049 · No. 89	● Below average
Def. success rate allowed	40.7% · No. 56	● Average / mixed
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.0% · No. 15	● Elite
Havoc created	14.4% · No. 91	● Below average

Advanced-stat read: The 2025 offense was poor across adjusted efficiency, EPA, success rate, explosiveness and havoc allowed. The defense prevented explosives well, but its adjusted/EPA and havoc marks were only average-to-poor.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Bill Belichick - returning	● ↔ Year 2 provides program continuity, but the rebuild still needs measurable offensive progress.
OC / play-caller	◆ Bobby Petrino - from Arkansas OC / interim HC	● ↑ Clear power-run/protection plan raises the offensive floor
DC	Steve Belichick - returning; medical leave at latest status	● ↔ Defensive game-day caller remains unresolved

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Billy Edwards Jr.	Wisconsin	● ↑ Named opening starter and defined veteran QB1 after a poor 2025 passing environment.
◆ TE Jelani Thurman	Ohio State	● ↔ Mackey-recognized top TE candidate without proven top-tier production.
◆ WR Trech Kekahuna	Wisconsin	● ↔ Projects as the slot lead and helps rebuild a receiver room around Jordan Shipp.
◆ OL Andrew Threatt	Charleston Southern	● ↔ Strong starter candidate in a rebuilt OL; translation remains uncertain.

Out	To	Loss
QB Gio Lopez	Wake Forest	● ↓ 2025 QB production leaves; QB Billy Edwards Jr. is the direct replacement.
OL Austin Blaske	NFL (L.A. Rams), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Starting-caliber OL loss in an already rebuilt unit.
OL Miles McVay	Mississippi State	● ↓ Experienced offensive-line departure adds to the best-five uncertainty.
TE Jake Johnson	Auburn	● ↓ Meaningful tight-end departure increases the importance of Thurman/Warren/Easter producing quickly.

Offensive net: ● ↑ modest upgrade at quarterback/play-calling but substantial continuity risk across the offensive line and supporting cast

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ LB Derek McDonald	Syracuse	● ↔ Projected starter whose recovery from a season-ending 2025 injury remains a monitor.
◆ LB Peyton Seelmann	Richmond	● ↔ Expected starter and Butkus watchlist honoree who helps replace House/Gbayor/Simpson.
◆ EDGE Jaylen Harvey	Penn State	● ↔ Significant newcomer in the edge rotation around EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude.
◆ DB Ade Willie	Michigan State	● ↔ Major corner/nickel competition piece in a secondary replacing several veteran contributors.

Out	To	Loss
LB Mikai Gbayor	Florida State	● ↓ Major 2025 linebacker contributor departs, increasing reliance on transfer replacements.
LB/DB Khmori House	Arkansas	● ↓ Significant 2025 defensive contributor leaves, further reducing continuity in the second level.
CB Marcus Allen	NFL (Minnesota), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Important defensive-back contributor exits on a NFL signing path.
CB Thaddeus Dixon	NFL (N.Y. Giants), undrafted free agent	● ↓ High-impact defensive-back departure on an NFL path.

Defensive net: ● ↓ clear continuity downgrade with enough transfer talent and Abou Jaoude's edge presence to remain functional, but substantial uncertainty at linebacker and defensive back

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Bobby Petrino power-run/protection-first attack with situational tempo and chunk-play intent.	Settled QB Billy Edwards Jr. plus varied RB/WR/TE options.	A rebuilt OL after a 2025 offense poor in efficiency and havoc avoidance.
Defense	Front built around EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude with transfer reinforcement.	Proven edge anchor and elite 2025 explosive-play prevention.	Low returning production and major LB/DB departures.
Special teams	Availability-driven specialist rebuild.	SP+ ranks the unit No. 32 and multiple contingencies exist.	K Rece Verhoff is unavailable; punter and long-snapper continuity is gone.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↑	Medium	QB Billy Edwards Jr. is the named starter and gives the new offense a defined operator.
RB	● B-	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Demon June provides a stable returning piece for the power-run foundation.
WR	● C+	● ↔	Medium	WR Jordan Shipp leads a mixed returner/transfer group without a proven high-end ceiling.
TE	● B-	● ↑	Medium	TE Jelani Thurman adds upside and a bigger role in the new offensive structure.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Low	Several candidates return or arrive, but the final five remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↔	Medium	EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude is a proven pass-rush anchor for a rebuilt front.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Low	Major departures and an unresolved health return leave heavy newcomer dependence.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Low	Several veteran departures force a new corner/safety combination with low certainty.
Special teams	● C+	● ↓	Low	Kicker eligibility and punter/long-snapper turnover create substantial role uncertainty.
Coaching	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	OC Bobby Petrino clarifies the offensive plan, while the defensive game-day structure remains less settled.
Overall	● B-	● ↑	Medium-low	Quarterback and offensive play-calling are clearer, but low continuity keeps the rebound projection modest.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Billy Edwards Jr. (TR: Wisconsin)	QB	● Solid Power 4 starter / offense-floor setter	-	Named the season-opening starter and gives Petrino a defined operator for the new offense.
Melkart Abou Jaoude	EDGE	● High-end conference starter / pass-rush anchor	Bednarik · Bronko Nagurski	Returns after a 10.5-sack 2025 and is the clearest established piece of a rebuilt defense.
Demon June	RB	● Above-average Power 4 lead-back candidate	Doak Walker	One of the offense's more stable returning pieces and central to Petrino's power-run foundation.
Jordan Shipp	WR	● Above-average Power 4 starter / primary outside target	-	Top returning outside target in a receiver room mixing returnees and transfers.
◆ Jelani Thurman (TR: Ohio State)	TE	● High-upside starting tight-end candidate	John Mackey	Top TE candidate and a key way Petrino can add size/structure to an offense seeking more efficient explosive plays.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Peyton Seelmann (TR: Richmond)	LB	● Projected major-role transfer	Butkus	Expected to help rebuild a linebacker unit replacing major 2025 contributors.
◆ Derek McDonald (TR: Syracuse)	LB	● Projected starting transfer / availability monitor	-	Potential starting-level answer at linebacker, but his recovery from a season-ending 2025 injury remains unresolved.
Aidan Banfield	OL	● Important returning starter candidate	-	Returns from a 2025 injury and is one of the higher-confidence pieces in a line with no settled final five.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Moderately difficult for a bowl-bubble team, with little room for a slow OL or defensive rebuild.
Difficulty	● 7/10 · Difficult · SP+ SOS No. 35
Hardest stretch	at Clemson → Notre Dame → at Pittsburgh → at Duke
Swing games	TCU (Dublin), at Pittsburgh, at Duke, Syracuse, at Virginia, NC State
Advantage	Two early byes, Sept. 5 and Sept. 26, provide installation/recovery time around the TCU/Clemson/Notre Dame opening sequence.
Expected	5.3 wins · most likely 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	UNC's 4-8 2025 record and No.15 ACC poll slot create a natural discount narrative.
Back them when	QB Billy Edwards Jr. is protected well enough for OC Bobby Petrino to stay balanced and EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude can drive pressure.
Fade/pass when	Pricing assumes the OL rebuild is solved, or DC Steve Belichick/K Rece Verhoff/secondary uncertainty adds operational risk.
Key monitor	Final OL five, DC Steve Belichick status/caller, K Rece Verhoff eligibility and kicker winner, LB Derek McDonald health, secondary order
Week 1 baseline	North Carolina +6.0 vs. TCU (Dublin, neutral) · rating-only baseline; North Carolina primer +3.5 minus TCU primer +9.5; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: North Carolina +7.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

North Carolina enters Year 2 with a clearer offensive plan: QB Billy Edwards Jr. is named QB1 and OC Bobby Petrino brings a defined power-run/protection structure. EDGE Melkart Abou Jaoude remains the defensive centerpiece, but low returning production leaves most of that side in transition.

Five wins is the baseline, with bowl eligibility reachable if the rebuilt OL becomes functional and the new defense avoids major communication or availability problems. The roster remains too unsettled for a confident breakout projection.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [fall camp](#) · [2025 stats](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [position/camp update](#) · [QB Billy Edwards wins Tar](#) · [UNC Football 2026 Position Review](#)

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